

NIGERIA'S KIDNAPPING ECONOMY: A 12-MONTH REPORT

July 2025 - June 2026 — Ransom Payments, Scale, and the North-Central Burden

Prepared for AVM Morgan (Rtd) — North-Central Security Summit supporting material

Executive Summary

Kidnapping for ransom has become one of Nigeria's most lucrative and fastest-growing criminal industries. Over the 12 months from July 2025 to June 2026, SBM Intelligence documented 7,825 kidnap victims across 1,411 separate incidents nationwide — a 66% year-on-year surge — with 1,142 people killed and over ₦7.78 billion (\$5.79 million) in ransom paid to armed groups. This is not opportunistic crime; it is an organised, self-financing economy that funds further attacks, weapons purchases, and territorial expansion by armed groups. North-Central Nigeria carries a disproportionate share of this burden, with Niger and Plateau States emerging as the two most acute epicentres.

1. The National Picture (Jul 2025 - Jun 2026)

Metric	Figure	Source
Total kidnap victims	7,825	SBM Intelligence (2026)
Total recorded incidents	1,411	SBM Intelligence (2026)
Year-on-year increase in victims	66%	SBM Intelligence (2026)
Deaths resulting from kidnap events	1,142	SBM Intelligence (2026)
Total ransom paid (documented)	₦7.78 billion (~\$5.79M)	SBM Intelligence (2026)
NC share of national conflict fatalities	~20-25%	ACLED (2026)

2. How the Ransom Economy Works

Ransom payments are rarely one-off transactions — they are the primary revenue stream sustaining banditry as an ongoing enterprise. The pattern is consistent across incidents: armed groups conduct mass abductions (mosque raids, highway ambushes, farm/village attacks), hold victims for days to weeks, negotiate through intermediaries, and collect payment often from a mix of family contributions, community levies, and in some cases state or local government facilitation. The ₦7.78 billion documented in this 12-month window is money that flows directly back into weapons, motorcycles, communications equipment, and recruitment — meaning every ransom paid measurably strengthens the next attack's capability. This is why security analysts increasingly describe it as an economy, not a crime wave: it has its own cash flow, negotiation infrastructure, and reinvestment cycle.

3. North-Central's Disproportionate Burden

Within this national picture, North-Central Nigeria is not a peripheral statistic — it is one of the two or three most active zones. Niger State alone is estimated to account for 350–450 deaths and 700–900 abductions in the broader Mar-Sep 2026 window used in the companion state-by-state report, driven by mass abduction events like the Borgu mosque raids. Plateau State recorded the highest confirmed, named-incident fatality count (121 deaths, May-11 Jul 2026 alone). Benue, Kwara, Kogi, Nasarawa and the FCT all show active, ongoing banditry and kidnapping activity at varying scales. See the companion document, `HUMAN_COST_BANDITRY_KIDNAPPING_NORTH_CENTRAL_STATISTICS.docx`, for the full state-by-state breakdown and named-incident sourcing.

4. What This Means

A 66% year-on-year rise in kidnap victims, alongside nearly ₦8 billion in documented ransom payments in a single year, confirms that this is a scaling, self-funding criminal economy — not a static or declining threat. Treating it purely as a law-and-order problem misses the economic logic driving its growth: as long as ransom payment remains the path of least resistance for victims' families and communities, the incentive structure for armed groups to keep expanding will remain intact. This reinforces the case for treating North-Central insecurity as a development emergency requiring coordinated regional response, not isolated state-level policing.

References

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